

Austin Killips

Portfolio

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@austintrace

Dear *you*, whoever that may be,

My name is Austin. I'm an activist, artist, and former professional cyclist.

Over the course of my career in sport I found the limits of my body and spirit as my exploits were increasingly imbued with a level of import and political significance that far exceeded me as an individual. And now, after nine years of sublimating masochistic impulses with all consuming challenges on a bicycle, my project as a professional athlete has come to an end.

Being an out trans woman in sport was something that veered from tenable and fulfilling to a nightmare that ruined my life between the years of 2019 and 2025. My win at a middling international level race in Silver City, New Mexico was the reason transsexual women were thrust into the spotlight and banned from sanctioned racing. When my results became ideological cudgels in the culture war over the course of 2023 I was forced to reckon with what my practice and place was in sport. So I started pedaling nonstop until something snapped. 20,000 miles, two records set on some of the most difficult backpacking trails in the world, and one cathartic 7 hour car ride across an international border with a stranger later was what it took to make peace with my lot.

Now I'm here, writing to *you*, about whatever it is I've done and am currently doing. I hope that what you see below is a coherent reflection of my creative impulses and the importance I have placed on being in relation with others. The line between pedaling professionally and making art is that they are both relational exercises. Opportunities to share space and time with others. The artifacts I produce exist to facilitate more moments like the ones that sustained me as an athlete, when, time and time again, some people that I'd never met have welcomed me into their homes, lives, cars, and worlds.

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MR. LEATHER

casual encounters

m4m m4w w4w t4m m4t t4w w4t t4t mw4mw mw4w

4m w4mw m4mw w4ww m4mm mm4m ww4w wv

— F
— F

casual encounters

~~THE PERSONAL AD AS A CONFESSION~~

~~BOOTH PHENOMENOLOGY OF CLO~~

~~SETED HOOKUPS ARTIST STATEM~~

~~ENT ENGLISH SUPPLEMENT SUR~~

~~RVEILLANCE AND VIRTUAL CRU~~

~~SING AFTER CRAIGSLIST ON~~

~~THE APARTMENTS I WAS INV~~

~~ITED INTO AS A TEENAGER~~

~~PART OF I~~

AN ASIDE ON FANTASIES

I kept rewriting this addendum to my short film about cruising to familiar dead ends. It finally stopped after I took a walk and came home with a book that would have been an unlikely purchase a year ago. John Berger's name would have caught my eye but after a few pages an overwhelming sense of being out of my depth would have led me elsewhere. I still know nothing of Alberto Giacometti's Sculptures on a technical level but my housemates are learning how to sand cast. The thought of one of them pulling the book off the shelf as they tumble down the rabbit hole of a new method for creating things was an invitation.

"Observed by a third person desire is a short parenthesis. Experienced from within it is an immanence and an entrance into plenitude ... the plenitude of a silence, a darkness." (Berger, 39)

Berger never imposes on the image or its object. Words manufacture boundaries around the sacred. A shared act reduced to a tidy definition is deprived of a life giving atopolis. It becomes an experience, something we purport to know, stake a claim in, and think we can have. But I cannot have the object of my desire in the flesh. I cannot have You just as I cannot relinquish the whole of my self for You.

Bearing skin and uttering closeted yearnings at hello is the illusion of an invitation. A doomed attempt to circumvent the part where we exchange hiding places. I cannot hide when I'm with You. The encounter endlessly rewrites and complicates those desires formed at a distance. When our bodies meet the contradiction of a closeted fantasy is laid bare.

- Berger, John, and Marc Trivier. *My Beautiful*. B. Mondadori, 2008.

A POEM ABOUT CRUISING

I've slept with many strange men
who were older than me
with hands that felt foreign

We would meet
Talk without saying anything
and, in some capacity, fuck

Sometimes we would finish
When the fantasy couldn't accomodate the unfamiliar
we would never arrive

Eventually we'd put our clothes back on
Talk without saying anything
and never meet again

Because the parking lot of his apartment wasn't the fantasy

Nor was the walk from the car
or the awkward hello
or eyes that kept searching for a connection

There wasn't a bookshelf with photos on it
An attempt at a kiss
Dry hands on disinterested skin

In the fantasy conversations didn't bookend an ecstatic release

The other of my imagination was always familiar
Always a means to an end

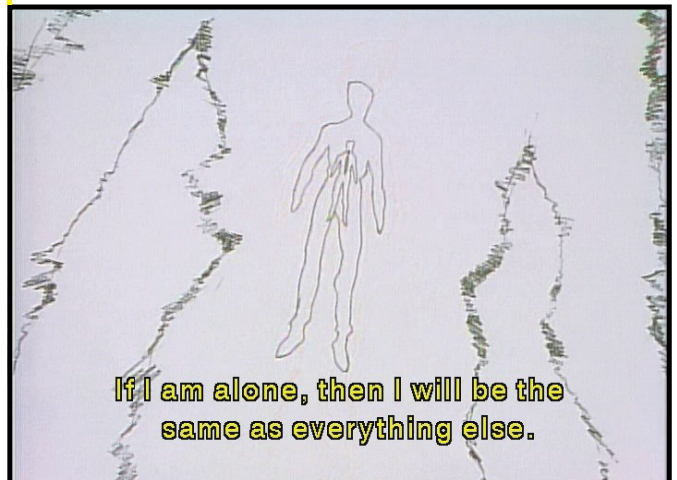
ON THE GLORIFICATION OF SUFFERING AND SOLITUDE

Reflections from the Arizona Trail

There is a belief in ultra-endurance sports that what defines a worthy effort, one that won't carry the dreaded asterisk, is "self-support". It is an ethos that pervades many corners of the ultra world but a gulf exists between what I've encountered in cycling compared to thru-hiking or running. A bit before completing my go of the AZT, Heather "Anish" Anderson successfully finished a completely "unsupported" hike that involved no store stops or caches. She carried all of the calories, water, and gear needed for the traverse from one border to the other. It was an incredible accomplishment done in service of a noble cause (Anderson is fundraising for people who lack access to clean water around the world through the Sawyer Foundation). Her run was as unsupported as it gets without carrying a shovel and cutting your own trail a long the way. Peeing blood, sustaining head trauma, and running out of food barely scratches the surface of the hurdles she encountered. It's an awe inspiring feat that I could never imagine as an athlete.

I think that Anish was engaged in something fascinating and bigger than herself. In many ways her successful attempt of the trail, done to raise awareness and expand access to clean water, is in the spirit of the impersonal engagement with these efforts that I expand on below. Her suffering was an exercise in solidarity and an attempt to better the conditions of others. It was not an end but a means. But as someone on a bike it's hard to imagine an effort truly self-supported in this vein. In part this is because ultra-endurance cycling has been fixated not on regulating material things but on the nebulous notion of emotional support. What is sacrosanct is the self-supported effort, "true aloneness" as some claim. Only you and the populations of every town you encounter along the way, the hotels that are legal according to the rules but not universally accessible, shop clerks, and the bike shop employees who may fix your bicycle. It's only you out there with your trusty wallet that helps you patronize the towns that exist in small part thanks to being along these fabled routes. Money, unlike the sinister presence of the documentarian, is certainly not a thing that could incur "undue moral hazard".

I can't shake how this fixation on a finicky notion of self-support in ultra-cycling all feels uniquely American. Impossibly tangled up with the protestant ethic and the mythos of the rugged individual. In some ways it even feels tangentially linked to our nation's history of homesteading with this glorification of leaving behind the creature comforts and connections we hold dear to embark on a grand journey traversing the great expanses of the Western United States in search of ourselves.



Nor can I shake the sense that traipsing through land that isn't mine propelled by an illusion of autonomy would be like settler colonial cosplay. How can we ever cut our ties of support by rolling across a start line or claim an accomplishment with our bodies as wholly our own? Every feat is possible thanks only to a medley of circumstance and the people we share a world with. People who give themselves to me as I give myself to them. We are not rugged individuals, we are creatures who depend on and are undone by one another. Severing those ties when the clock starts ticking feels like a performative nod to something that could never be realized. My body's capacity is the product of the network of people and technologies that have supported my journey in professional sport. My bike is at the start line thanks to the generosity of my friends and sponsors. Being able to fix mechanical issues is the product of years of skill sharing in bike shops. The opportunity for me to race the AZT was thanks to kind souls giving me a place to stay while sharing knowledge and bike parts.

Hi,

This *was* piece number three (3)

But this page is now intentionally blank

APOLOGIES FOR THE INCONVENIENCE

THANK YOU FOR UNDERSTANDING

Hi,

This was piece number four (4)

But this page is now intentionally blank

APOLOGIES FOR THE INCONVENIENCE

THANK YOU FOR UNDERSTANDING

**MORE BELOW MORE BELOW MORE BELOW
MORE BELOW MORE BELOW MORE BELOW
MORE BELOW MORE BELOW MORE BELOW
MORE BELOW MORE BELOW MORE BELOW**

sometimes I act into the world
in ways that exceed me

ure

Lifestyle



The Guardian

US

rugby union Tennis Cycling F1 Golf Boxing Rugby league Racing US sports

Trump singled me out for ruining women's sport. This is my response to him
Austin Killips

I try to respond to those moments thoughtfully

“my wins only served to generate more artifacts for the right's culture wars, while I remained unable to garner even a sliver of the institutional recognition that friends and fellow competitors with similar palmares have found.”

““Transgender people lost the inclusion battle in sport ages ago. International governing bodies for competitions in running, cycling, chess, swimming, darts and more have repeatedly caved to pressure and helped shift the Overton window to exclude trans people from public life more broadly. The world's least gracious winners insist on kicking sand in our eyes.”

this was one of those moments

“They are, for lack of a better word, cowards who don't want to do the actual work of empowering and supporting athletes.”

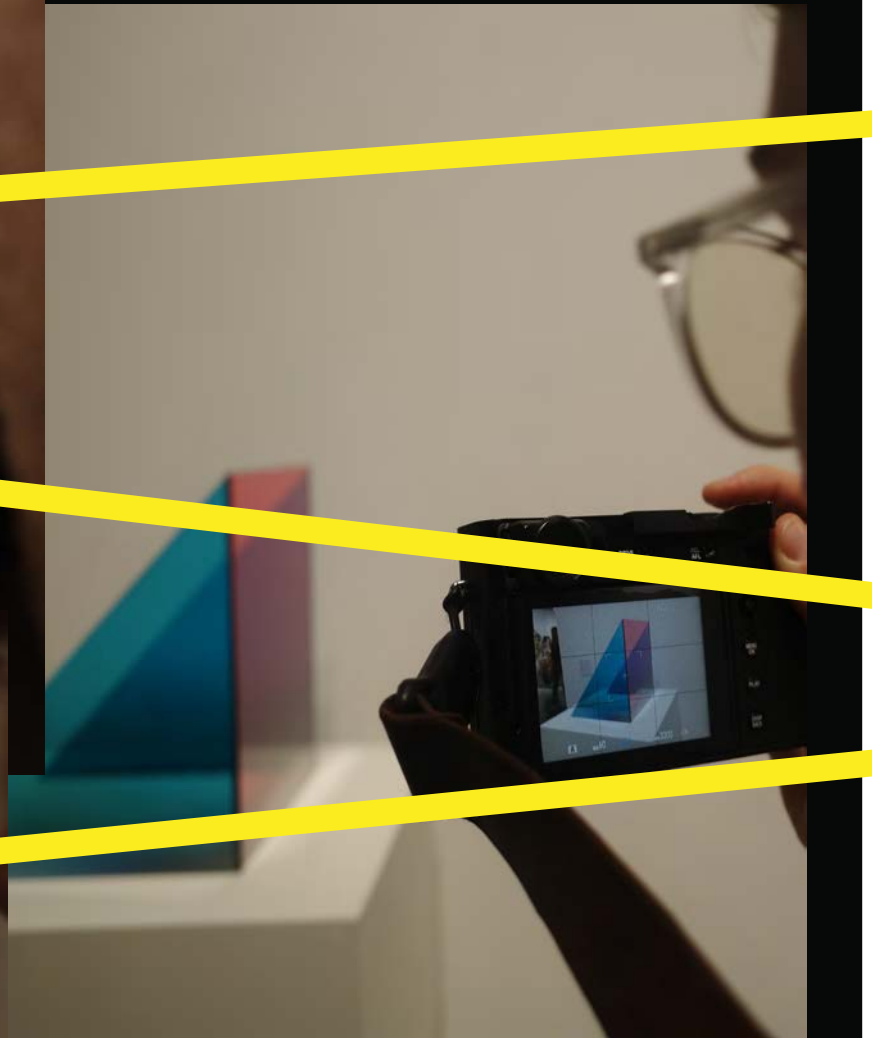
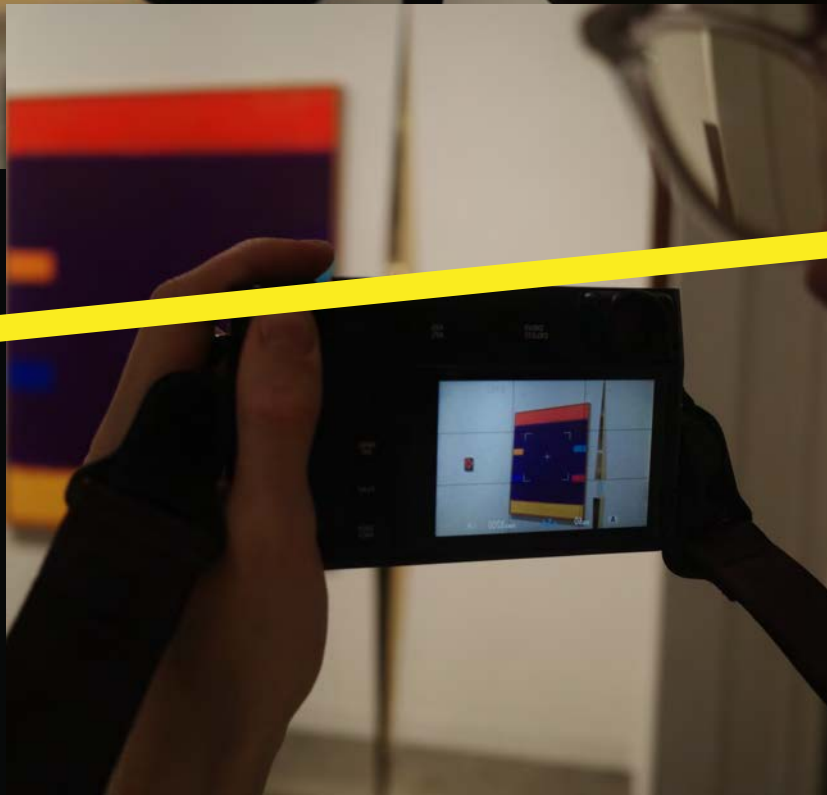
“They found a scapegoat, and all they have done is enrich themselves with five-figure speaking fee tours, while taking the oxygen out of the room. The only lane they've made is one that encourages women to quit competing for a life of news appearances and college campus speaking tours.

So my argument is quite simple. Maybe you take umbrage with trans people in sports, and in turn me (whatever, you won that battle). But if you purport to care about women's sports, about girls getting a fair chance at competing, you need to ask yourself why, at the height of a historic moment of sweeping and unchecked austerity measures, the loudest and wealthiest people in the room have built a movement that culminated in this: an executive order that establishes a precedent to strip funding away from women in sport.”

Read my op-ed

HERE HERE HERE HERE HERE

**FRAMING
THE
GAZE**



COMPOSITION STUDIES

@ art basel miami



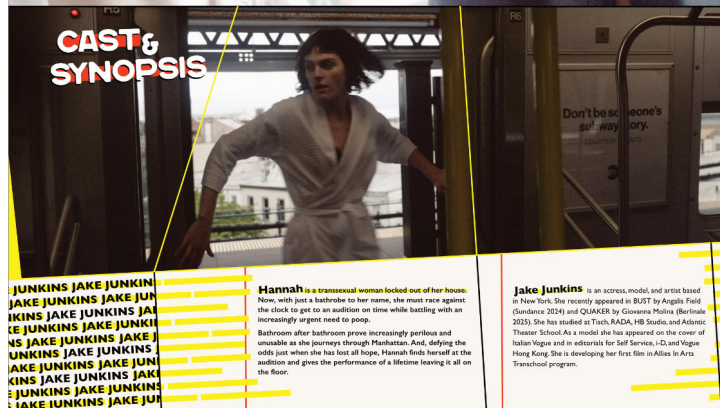
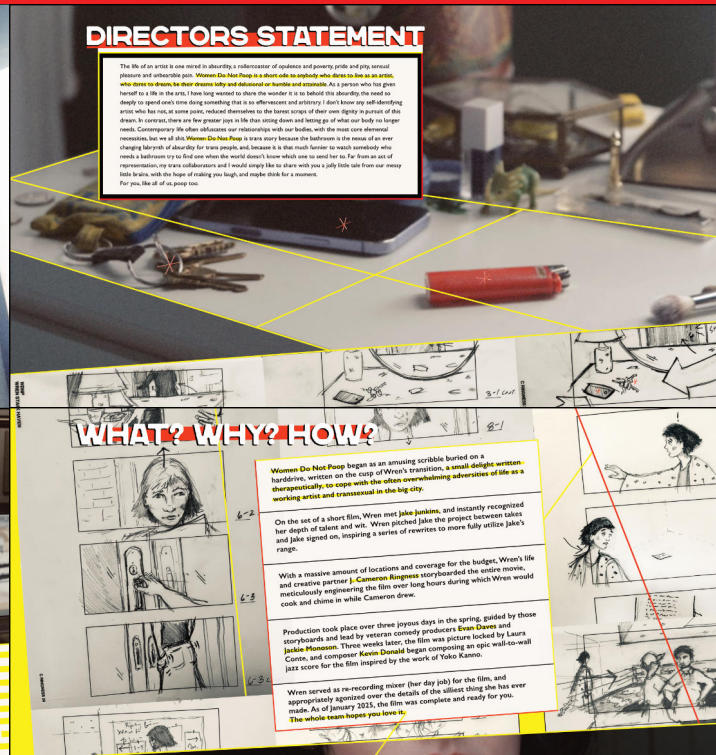
COMPOSITION STUDIES
@ art basel miami



CONSIDERING THE NEEDS OF THE ART BUYER



(commisioned media kit for film)

[illegible]**INFO**

Writer/Director Wren Stark Haven	Storyboard Artist J. Cameron Ringness	Hannah Jake Junkins
Producers Evan Daves Jackie Monoson	Production Designer Sara Mardon	Pizza Guy Samuel Leiberman
Executive Producer Lily Weisberg Michael Bloom	Editor Laura Conte	Casting Director Miranda Gruss
Cinematography Ella Gibney	Composer Kevin Donald	The Dolls Nicky Demarie Jamie Ponto T Mitsock
	Script Supervisor Frankie Ferrari	

- Completed
 — Duration
 — Aspect Ratio
 — Format
 — Sound
 — 2025
 — 41m 44s 02f
 — 1.85
 — Digital
 — Dolby Atmos

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THIS PROJECT WAS A COLLECTIVE LABOR OF LOVE
THANK YOU FOR WATCHING :)

**WOMEN
DO NOT
POOP**

Show Poster



Postcards



Gallery Handouts



Front

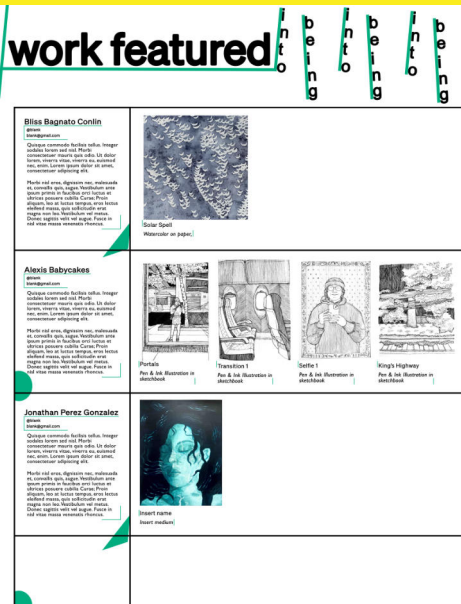


Back



Front

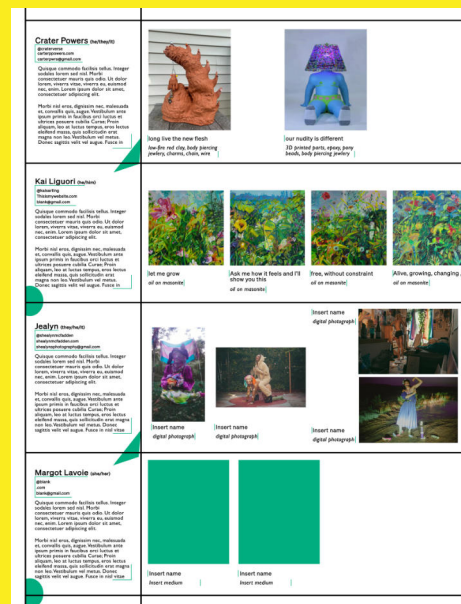
Inventory of Pieces Featured



Page 1



Page 2



Page 3, et al

Hi,

this portfolio was made for you

I hope you found it compelling

END OF WORK SAMPLES

THANK YOU FOR LOOKING